Leading a session: You are not alone

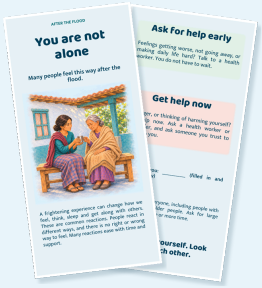
For people trained in psychological first aid, with a supervisor and known referral routes.



Immediate danger? Pause the session, stay with the person and get urgent help now. Do not leave them alone. Stay until a health worker or responder takes over; feeling calmer is not the end point. Full procedure and contacts: page 2.



Poster A3



Leaflet, tri-fold

Your materials

Poster · a shared focus

For a group: open the discussion, invite observations and return to the main message. Make sure everyone can see; do not read every line aloud.

Leaflet · detail to take home

For a question or a closer look, and to keep or share. Open only the relevant section and offer to read it together.

Use one or both, in any order. Focus on what people need, not on finishing both materials.

Before people arrive

- ☐ Choose a safe, quiet and accessible place, and ask the group leader or organiser for permission. Hang the poster where everyone can see it; bring enough leaflets.
- ☐ Fill in and check the help contacts on page 2; do not hand out leaflets with unverified contacts. Know who can support a private conversation or help someone get urgent support.
- ☐ Plan language and access: simple words, large print, more time, or a sign language interpreter if needed and available. Offer alternatives if the picture or text is not accessible.

The session

about 15 minutes · do not rush someone or delay urgent help to finish the plan

1 Welcome and explain the purpose

2 min · either material

DO Introduce yourself. Explain that joining is voluntary, people may listen without speaking, and nobody has to describe what happened to them.

SAY *"Welcome. Today we will talk about feelings people may have after the flood. The main message is: you are not alone. We will explore small things that may help and where to ask for support."*

2 Invite observations, then listen

3 min · poster if useful

DO Invite people to describe Karuna and Asha sitting together before explaining the message. Allow silence and different answers. If using only the leaflet, invite an observation about its cover instead.

ASK *"What do you notice in this picture?"*

SAY *"People can react differently. You do not have to tell your own story."*

3 Explore one useful choice

5 min · move between materials as needed

DO Ask what already helps. Use the choices printed in the material you are using as prompts; open the leaflet if someone wants more detail. Discuss what is possible here, without asking everyone to follow the same action. Breathing is optional; stop if it makes someone feel worse.

ASK *"What helps you or your family on a hard day? Is there one small thing you would like to try?"*

4 Make the route to help clear

2 min · relevant help section

DO Use the help section of either material. Explain the locally checked contact and how to reach help. Invite questions about access, not public accounts of personal distress. Offer a private conversation; use page 2 if concern arises.

SAY *"You do not have to wait until it gets very bad. We can talk privately about how to reach help."*

5 Check understanding and close

2 min · offer the leaflet to keep

DO Offer the leaflet, show how it opens, and help the person find the relevant section. Check understanding gently, not as a test. Thank people and tell them where to find you after the session.

ASK *"If you or someone at home wanted support, could you show me where you would look for help?"*

Safety, referral and worker boundaries

Get urgent help now if someone:

SIGNS

- Talks about suicide, or about harming themselves or someone else
- Cannot keep themselves safe, or cannot care for a child in their care
- Seems very confused, or not aware of where they are

WHAT TO DO

1. Stay with the person. Do not leave them alone.
2. Get urgent help now: a health worker, responder or the emergency service in this area.
3. It is okay to ask directly about suicide. Asking does not put the idea in their mind.
4. Stay until a health worker or responder takes over. Feeling calmer is not the end point.

If someone becomes upset

- Stay calm and stay close.
- Offer a quieter place away from the group, if they wish.
- Do not force them to talk. Ask what they need now.
- Stay as long as they want, or until someone they trust is with them.

PFA: Look, Listen and Link

Look: safety, urgent needs, people who are very distressed
Listen: ask about needs and concerns; help them feel calm
Link: basic needs, services, information, loved ones

Talk privately and link to further help if

- Feelings get worse, do not improve, or make daily life very hard
- They are not able to look after themselves or their children
- A body problem worries them: pain, fever, injury, or not eating or sleeping for days

With the person's agreement: explain the options, go with them if you can, and share only what is needed.

Do

- Use simple words and respect silence
- Respect people's beliefs and ways of coping, within safety
- Give everyone time to answer
- Follow up privately with anyone who asks

Do not

- Ask anyone to describe what happened to them in front of the group
- Tell people how they should feel, or that they should be over it
- Diagnose, or give advice about medicines
- Promise help you cannot give

Your role

This guide supports a session; it does not replace psychological first aid training. Use your training, supervisor and known referral routes.

Look after yourself too: take breaks, talk with your supervisor or a colleague, and ask for support when you need it.



Help contacts for this area fill in and check before the talk

Health worker or facility _____

Urgent help _____

Other support _____



Sources: WHO, Psychological First Aid: Guide for Field Workers (2011); WHO, Doing What Matters in Times of Stress (2020); IASC, Guidelines on MHPSS in Emergency Settings (2007); WHO/UNHCR, mhGAP Humanitarian Intervention Guide (2015). This material draws on these publications; it was not created by WHO or IASC, which are not responsible for its content.